XI—A House of Turbulence

> ‘Tyranny is unlawful in everyone, especially in a sovereign who is the guardian of the world.’
>
> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

It was five years earlier, when Akbar returned from Patna and inaugurated his Ibadat Khana, pushed through his mansabdari reforms, and began to look for the Truth, that his uncle Sulaiman of Badakhshan arrived in Fatehpur, mouth agape at the splendour of his nephew’s realm. If Babur’s sons had failed to grasp the destiny he left for them, his grandson had fulfilled his dream. The parade of gaily decorated elephants and bejewelled cheetahs proclaimed a well-justified pride in what he had achieved. Babur, after all, had only assumed the title of padishah; Akbar was the real thing.[1] Under his watch, beleaguered Timurids did not flee north across the Indus to lick their wounds in Kabul and squabble over its possession; they came south, instead, seeking the aid and refuge of the emperor of Hindustan.

Sulaiman had lost his kingdom. Or, as some might say, he had lost the kingdom of his redoubtable queen, Haram Begum. Annette Beveridge writes that Sulaiman ‘held Badakhshan so long as Haram’s watchful eye was on him, and lost it at her death’[2] – two clauses that hold a book’s worth of adventure between them. Sulaiman’s life, over the past years, had been a relentless mix of power politics and soap opera.

After Kamran’s defeat, exile and death, his cousin Sulaiman had developed a fondness for Khanim, one of Kamran’s widows. That he dared entertain such a thought while married to Haram is testament to his Timurid blood, but he had underestimated his wife. Haram had ‘anticipated matters’, writes Abul Fazl, and married Khanim off to her son, Ibrahim.[3]

It is no surprise that the two women were possessed by ‘evil thoughts’ for each other thereafter. Things got worse after Ibrahim died in battle. For the rest of her life, his mother would dress in dark blue, the Central Asian colour of mourning, but her grief did not spark a reconciliation with Ibrahim’s widow. Instead, Haram began to taunt Khanim, hoping that she would run away to her father’s home. Khanim was made of stern stuff, however; besides, she had a young son, Shahrukh, whom she was raising to